

GUIDE TONE SYSTEM

Strip the 5th. Root + 3rd + 7th. Two positions, one rule — the minimum viable voicing for maximum harmonic clarity.

The **5th adds nothing unique** to chord identity — it doesn't tell you whether a chord is major, minor, or dominant. The **3rd and 7th are the guide tones**: they define quality and functional movement. Stripping to these two notes + root gives you a thin, sophisticated sound and makes voice leading even easier.

THE GUIDE TONE RULE THROUGH CYCLE 5

Through Cycle 5 (ascending 4ths), just **FLIP between Position 1 and Position 2** on every chord change. The 3rd becomes the 7th of the next chord, and the 7th resolves to the 3rd — smooth by design.

GUIDE TONE POSITIONS — MAJOR AND MINOR 7THS

Cmaj7

Guide tones: E (3rd) · B (maj7)

R

3 — R·3·7

7

R

3↑ — R·7·3

7

C · E · B

C · B · E

(7th below 3rd)

Dm7

Guide tones: F (b3rd) · C (b7)

b7

R

P1 — b3 · B7

b7

R

P2 — b3↑ · bB3

D · F · C

D · C · F

(b7th below b3rd)

CYCLE 5 GUIDE TONE FLOW (FLIPPING P1 ↔ P2)

Cmaj7	Fmaj7	Bø7	Em7	Am7	Dm7	G7
P1	P2	P1	P2	P1	P2	P1
C · E · B	F · E · A	B · D · A	E · D · G	A · C · G	D · C · F	G · B · F

TEXTURE PRINCIPLE

Guide tones = THIN texture. Use when you want space, sophistication, and room for the melody to breathe. Adding the 5th back = FULL texture. Knowing when to use each is what separates advanced players from intermediate players — it's not about using more notes, it's about controlling density intentionally.